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The background of the cover features a man with dark hair and a beard, seen from the chest up in profile, looking towards the right. He is wearing a blue cloak with a yellow hexagonal grid pattern. Each hexagon contains a different landscape scene in shades of blue and white, including mountains, forests, a lighthouse, a compass rose, and various natural features. The background behind the man is a dark purple, textured landscape with jagged mountains and a small figure flying in the sky.

Matthijs Holter's
HEXCRAWL
WORLDBUILDING
DESIGN
GUIDEBOOK



HEXCRAWL WORLDBUILDING DESIGN GUIDEBOOK

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FOREWORD

The first two books covered structure and encounters. This book teaches you to build the world around those encounters.

I wrote the first two books because I kept seeing the same problems at the table. Game Masters (GMs) who designed brilliant encounters but dropped them into worlds that felt like wallpaper. The missing piece was always the connections between hexes.

The world comes alive when its pieces connect. A keep sits on a hill because it overlooks a trade road. The road exists because a coastal village trades salt fish for timber from the forest settlement inland. The terrain shaped the economy, the economy created the road, and the road justified the keep.

That chain of connections is what this book teaches you to build. This book is opinionated. I recommend specific methods and techniques, warn you about failure modes, and tell you what I think works best, with reasoning, so you can adapt it to your game.

- Matthijs

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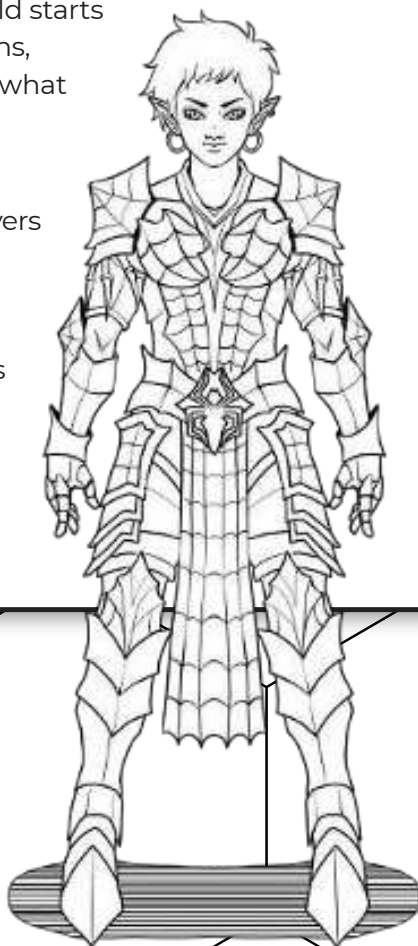
INTRODUCTION

Every hex on your map implies a network of connections around it. In this introduction, I show you why connections between places matter more than the places themselves, and how to keep your first build small enough to finish in one evening.

The World Between the Hexes

A world feels real when everything in it connects to at least one other thing. A mountain range forces rivers south AND creates passes that become trade routes. Rivers create valleys AND attract settlers. Settlers build roads AND attract bandits. Each element connects to at least one other: what caused it, or what it causes. Build these connections and the world starts running itself. That web of connections, where each hex points to the next, is what you'll learn to build here.

Show, don't tell: History, factions, and setting background should reach players through play, not through backstory dumps. Weave setting details into discovery, ruins, rumors, and NPC conversations. Think of them as spices in a meal, not a menu to read beforehand. If players can't encounter it at the table, it doesn't belong in your prep.



How This Book Works

Chapter 1 gives you a playable region in one evening. Six steps, one session of prep, done. That single chapter is everything you need for session one. Chapters 2 through 7 are organized around the things you actually prep: terrain, settlements, factions, ruins, history, and growth.

Each chapter shows what to BUILD first, how to DEEPEN it when your game calls for more, and what to MAINTAIN between sessions.

- **BUILD:** before session one. The minimum that makes this element work.
- **DEEPEN:** when the basics aren't enough at the table. You go deeper into what already exists, rather than expanding the region outward (that's Chapter 7).
- **MAINTAIN:** between sessions. A ten-minute routine that keeps the world moving.

You don't read this book front to back. You build a region with Chapter 1, then open whichever chapter fixes the problem in front of you. Settlements feel generic? Chapter 3. Factions aren't driving conflict? Chapter 4. Terrain feels flat? Chapter 2. Each chapter stands on its own.

If you already have a region and want to improve it, Chapter 8 walks you through a review process that finds the biggest gap in your region and tells you which chapter will fix it.

Failure mode: You read every chapter, absorb dozens of techniques, and try to use them all at once. The region takes twenty hours instead of one evening, and you burn out before session one.

Summary:

- Start with the build procedure in Chapter 1 for a playable region in one evening. Open Chapters 2 through 7 when a specific element needs depth
- Every hex should point to at least one other: what caused it, or what it causes
- Resist the urge to use every technique at once. Pick the one your region needs most and save the rest for later

Start With a Region, Not a World

As in Book 1, I recommend twenty to thirty hexes. One region. Three to four terrain types. That's the scope of your first build, but you only key (meaning write detailed content for) five to eight of those hexes. The rest get a terrain type and a one-line note like "dense forest, rumored to be haunted" or "trade road leading to Aldenmere, three days east." Everything beyond the edges is rumors and compass directions.

Start with the ground under the characters' feet and build outward only when play demands it. When players reach the edges, you add another cluster of hexes in that direction. The world grows the way the campaign grows: outward from the characters, shaped by their choices. You won't ever build a region the players ignore.

The hierarchy: Your world breaks down into regions, each region into hexes, and each hex into the encounters players find there. This book works at the region level. You build one region at a time, and each region contains everything the party needs for a full campaign arc.

That's enough hexes to sustain a campaign arc, and few enough that you can key each one with real content.

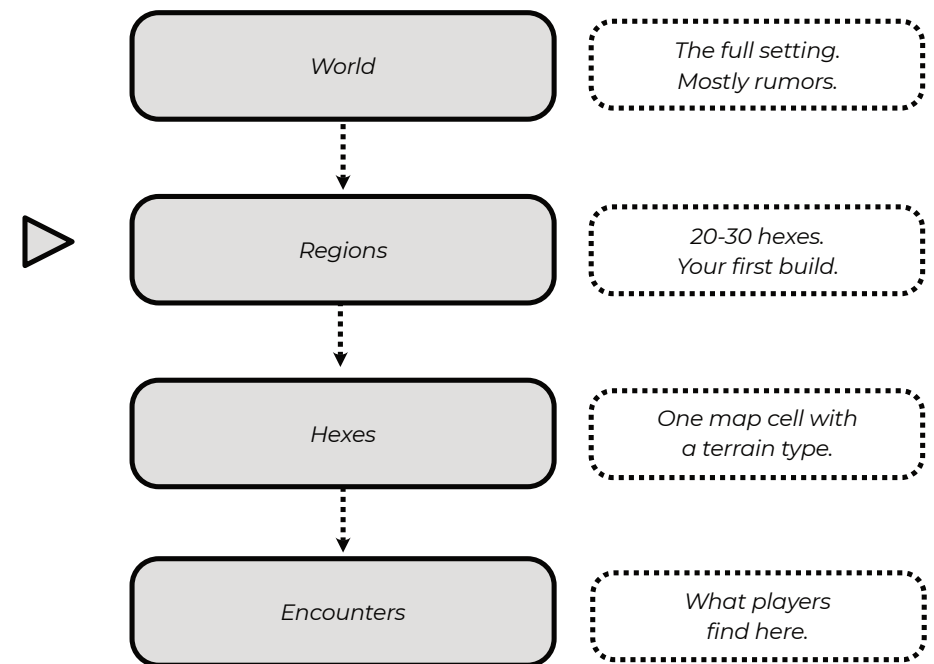
Failure mode: You build a continent with two hundred hexes, each with a one-line description. Play starts and the players spend six sessions in the same five hexes. The other 195 gather dust. You feel like you wasted forty hours of prep, because you did.

Summary:

- *Scope your first build to 20-30 hexes with three to four terrain types, but only key five to eight with real content. The rest get terrain and a one-line note*
- *The world grows outward from the characters as the campaign grows, so you never build a region the players ignore*
- *Thirty hexes of deep connections will always outperform two hundred hexes of shallow description*

Spatial Hierarchy

This book works at the region level



Build one region at a time. The world grows outward from the characters.

CHAPTER 1

BUILDING A REGION

These are the six steps to complete in your next prep session. In an hour or two, you will have a playable region ready for session one.

You'll learn:

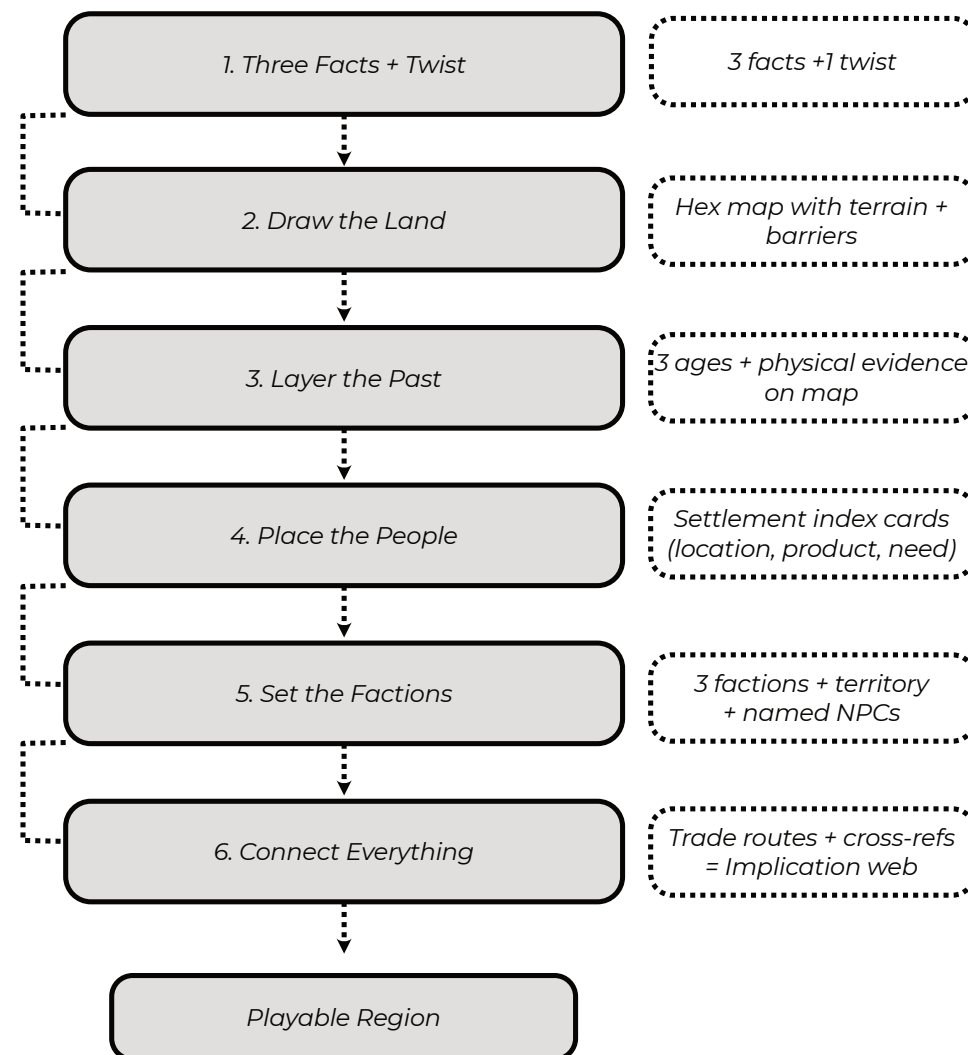
1. How to establish a region's identity with three facts and a twist
2. How to draw terrain that creates consequential travel decisions
3. How to layer history into physical features players actually encounter
4. How to place settlements that generate trade, conflict, and adventure
5. How to design factions whose goals collide
6. How to connect every element so the region plays as a web, not a list

The six steps below produce a playable region in one evening. Each step builds on what came before, so you never stare at a blank page.



Six-Step Build Procedure

Each step shapes the next



About ninety minutes from blank page to playable region.

Step 1: Three Facts and a Twist

Start with what everyone knows before the first session. You need three facts about the region and one twist. The facts orient players, and the twist makes them lean forward.

The three facts should be broad, concrete, and immediately useful:

- *“It’s a frozen river delta” tells players what to pack*
- *“The city-state of Haal taxes all river trade” tells them who has power*
- *“Giants built a canal network centuries ago” tells them what they’ll find in the wilderness*

Each fact supports the game directly.

The twist is the odd one out. It sits in tension with one or more of the facts, and that tension is where your campaign lives.

Examples:

Three facts:

- *“it’s a frontier,”*
- *“there’s a drought,”*
- *“the old empire left ruins everywhere.”*

Twist: *“the ruins are guarded by people who claim to be the empire’s heirs.”*

Now the players have questions. Are the guardians legitimate? What’s in those ruins that’s worth protecting?

Here’s a coastal example. Three facts:

- *“The Saltmere Isles are a chain of trading ports.”*
- *“The Confederacy’s navy protects all shipping lanes.”*
- *“Every island exports something the others need.”*

Twist: *“Ships have been vanishing between the islands, but no wreckage ever washes ashore.”*

The three facts paint stability. The twist cracks it open. Players immediately want to know what’s taking the ships, and who benefits from the fear.

And an urban one. Three facts:

- *“Verath is a guild city famous for its master artisans.”*
- *“The city has maintained diplomatic neutrality for a century.”*
- *“Its crafted goods are traded across the continent.”*

Twist: *“The city’s best artisans are disappearing one by one, and the guilds are blaming each other.”*

Neutrality and craftsmanship are the foundation. The vanishing artisans threaten both, and the guild accusations poison the city from the inside.

Read the three facts aloud at session zero: If players don’t ask a follow-up question about the twist, it’s too weak. Rewrite it on the spot. In my experience, the twist is worth more time than all three facts combined.

Failure mode: Four facts that all agree with each other produce a setting without tension. “It’s cold, there are mountains, people are tough, and the winters are harsh” is four facts pointing in the same direction. Players nod along and wait for you to tell them what’s interesting. The twist is what makes them lean forward.

Summary:

- *Three facts give players enough context to make real choices from session one*
- *The twist is the engine of your campaign. Without it, the region is scenery*
- *Test your twist at session zero: if nobody asks a question, rewrite it*

Step 2: Draw the Land

You need four decisions, in order:

1. *Where does water flow?*
2. *Where are the barriers?*
3. *What three to four terrain types fill the spaces between?*
4. *Where do those terrains transition into each other?*

Here, you're designing terrain with purpose: each decision shapes where people live, where conflict happens, and where players choose to explore. What works for me: sketch water and barriers first and resist the urge to detail terrain types until those two layers feel right.

Water comes first because it dictates where people live. Draw your major river. It flows downhill, so you've just decided which direction is higher elevation. Smaller rivers join it. Lakes form where water pools against barriers. Settlements cluster at river crossings, junctions, and river mouths. Forget geographical accuracy. Draw water that creates routes to follow and crossings to find.



Place two or three barriers: a mountain range, a deep canyon, a swamp that floods every spring. In a more fantastical setting, barriers can be supernatural: a cursed forest where compasses spin, a zone of dead magic where spells fail, an endless fog bank that swallows travelers who stray off the marked path. Barriers divide your map into zones and force detours. They make passes and bridges valuable. A region without barriers is a region where travel is a straight line.

Pick three to four terrain types for your region, and see if your barriers can separate them. Each type should play differently at the table: different encounters, different travel speeds, different resources. If two terrain types produce the same gameplay, merge them into one.

Draw the borders between terrain types as jagged, irregular lines. The hex where forest meets grassland near a river crossing is more interesting than any hex deep in uniform terrain. Those transition zones are where players make the most interesting choices.

Failure mode: If one terrain type dominates the map and there are no barriers, every day of travel feels the same. Players stop exploring because they already know what the next hex looks like.

Summary:

- *Water first, then barriers, then terrain types, then transitions. Each step builds on the one before it, so you never have to redraw what you already placed*
- *Barriers create the detours and chokepoints that make travel decisions consequential*
- *Terrain transitions and geographic intersections are where your best hexes live*

Step 3: Layer the Past

Ruins, roads, battlefields, and scars in the landscape are how players discover what came before. Your region needs a past that exists as physical features on the map.

I like to define the past by three ages. Each gets two sentences: what defined that era, and why it ended.

- *“The canal builders shaped the delta for three centuries. They vanished when the river shifted course and their capital flooded.”*

Six sentences total. Five minutes of work gives you three hundred years of history.

Now place evidence for each age on the map. One ruin, one old road connecting two points that no longer matter, two landscape scars: a burned forest that never regrew, a quarry that became a lake, a field of standing stones.

I place ruins from the oldest age in the most remote locations and recent ruins closer to current settlements. This gradient means the deeper players push into the wilderness, the older the history they uncover, rewarding exploration with discovery.

Physical evidence comes in many forms. Here are some to scatter across your map:

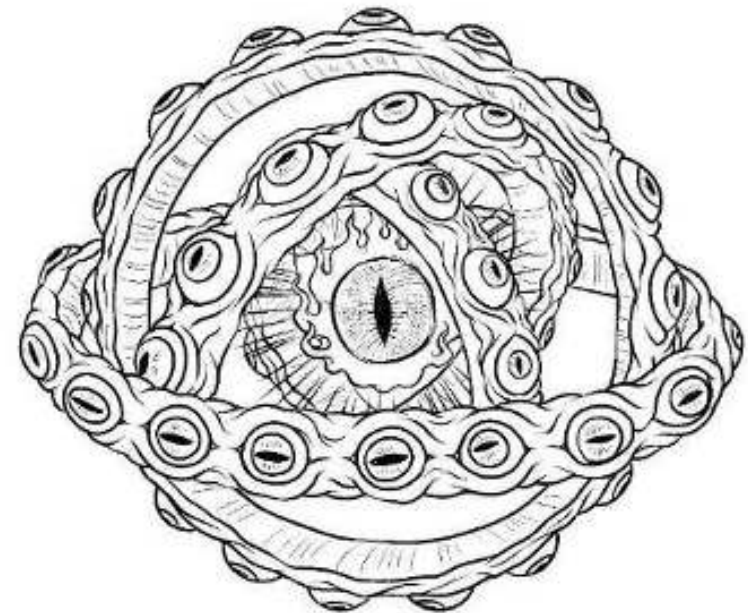
- Overgrown road beds leading nowhere anyone remembers
- Foundation stones repurposed in a farmer's wall
- A bridge too wide for the stream it crosses
- Weapon fragments turned up by a plow
- Carved symbols on cliff faces, their meaning lost
- A stone well larger and finer than the village that uses it
- Pottery shards in a riverbank after spring floods
- A canal lock half-buried in river mud

The past should connect to your twist from Step 1. If the twist involves people claiming to be an empire's heirs, then imperial ruins should be visible, contested, and central to the map. History that doesn't touch the present conflict is decoration.

Failure mode: Detailed history that exists only in your notes produces a GM who lectures and players who zone out. If the past isn't on the map, it isn't in the game.

Summary:

- *Three ages, two sentences each: if you can't summarize an era in two sentences, you're overbuilding*
- *Every historical age should leave physical evidence players can find, investigate, and loot*
- *Place older ruins deeper in the wilderness so exploration moves backward through time*



Step 4: Settle the People

Settlements go where geography gives people a reason to stop moving. River crossings, mountain passes, natural harbors, crossroads, and the edges of fertile land. If you can't point to the map and explain why a town is there, move it.

Each settlement needs four things written down:

- **Location reason:** *"sits at the only river crossing for fifty miles"*
- **What it produces:** *"timber from the eastern woods"*
- **What it needs:** *"iron, which comes overland from Durath"*
- **Current problem:** *"the crossing is clogging up with mud, and the mayor wants someone to clear it"*

These four entries give you everything required to run the settlement during play. When players ask questions you haven't prepared for, improvise from those four entries. The crossing town that needs iron and has a mud problem generates different improvisations than the mining town that exports iron and has a labor shortage.

Current problems should connect to the wider region. The mud-clogged crossing might be caused by upstream logging. The labor shortage might exist because workers left to join a faction. Every problem that points elsewhere on the map makes the region feel interconnected.

What works for me: write each settlement as a short note with four entries: location reason, product, need, and current problem. Keep the notes at hand during play.

Failure mode: Settlements placed for aesthetic reasons without geographic logic create a region that looks good on the map but falls apart when players ask "why is this here?"

Summary:

- *Geography dictates settlement placement: if you can't explain why a town is there, move it*
- *Four entries per settlement: location reason, product, need, current problem*
- *Every settlement problem should point to something else on the map*

The Build Procedure: Reference Card

Use this page during prep. Each step lists the key question you're answering, what you produce, and where to go deeper.

The Build Procedure

Step 1: Three Facts and a Twist Key question: What does everyone know, and what doesn't fit? Output: Three setting facts and one twist in a short note.

Step 2: Draw the Land Key question: Where does water flow, and what blocks travel? Output: A hex map with water, barriers, 3-4 terrain types, and transition zones. Go deeper: The Terrain card (Chapter 2).

Step 3: Layer the Past Key question: What three ages shaped this land, and what evidence remains? Output: Six sentences of history. One ruin per age, one old road, two landscape scars on the map. Go deeper: The Ruin Card (Chapter 5), History and Context (Chapter 6).

Step 4: Settle the People Key question: Why is each settlement where it is? Output: 2-3 settlement notes (location reason, product, need, problem). Go deeper: The Settlement Card (Chapter 3).

Step 5: Set the Factions Key question: What three groups want incompatible things? Output: Three faction sentences. Territory marked on map. One named NPC each. Go deeper: The Faction Card (Chapter 4), History and Context (Chapter 6).

Step 6: Connect Everything Key question: Does every hex point to at least one other hex? Output: Trade routes on map. One contested resource. Cross-references between hexes forming an implication web. Go deeper: History and Context (Chapter 6), Growing and Changing (Chapter 7).

Complete these six steps and you have a region ready for session one. It won't be finished. Regions never are. But it'll be playable, interconnected, and full of decisions with consequences. To see the full procedure in action, read the Greymire worked example that follows.

Step 5: Set the Factions

I recommend that you start with three factions. Each one gets a single sentence: who they are, what they want, and what they'll do next if the players don't intervene.

- *"The Ironveil Company wants to control the river trade and has been burning rival barges and threatening captains who won't pay tribute."*
- *"The Thornwood Wardens want to stop all logging in the eastern forest and have started burning lumber camps."*
- *"The old families of Durath want to restore the trade alliance and are sending envoys to every settlement."*

Factions range from a single powerful family to a regional empire's local garrison. The scale should match your region. In a 20-hex frontier, your factions might be a merchant company, a druid circle, and a local lord. In a trade hub, they could be rival guilds, a foreign embassy, and a crime syndicate. Match faction size to what fits your map.

Incompatible means the factions can't all get what they want. One faction wants to dam the river for farmland. Another needs the river flowing for trade. A third faction considers the river sacred and will fight anyone who touches it. Three goals, and satisfying any one of them blocks at least one other.

I make sure at least two faction goals conflict directly. The Ironveil Company's campaign of arson and intimidation on the river threatens Durath's trade alliance. The Thornwood Wardens' logging ban threatens every settlement that exports timber. These conflicts exist whether or not the players get involved. Factions act on their own timelines. If the players spend three sessions exploring ruins, the Ironveil Company is still burning barges and the Wardens are still burning camps.

My approach: mark faction territory on your GM map with color-coding or symbols. Players don't see these borders. They discover them through play: which settlement pays tribute to whom, which road has tolls, which village shuts its gates when certain colors ride in. The borders between territories are your most interesting hexes. A lumber camp at the edge of Warden territory is a powder keg, a trading post where Ironveil and Durath interests overlap is a place where NPCs have divided loyalties.

Give each faction one named NPC that players can talk to. Not a full character sheet. A name, a title, and one memorable trait. *"Voss, Ironveil enforcer, always eating."* That's enough. You'll develop them through play. Chapter 4 shows how factions move between sessions and leave traces players can follow.

Failure mode: All three factions want roughly the same thing. *"Control the region"* is not a goal, it is a default. When every faction pushes in the same direction, the world feels like a monolith with different flags. Distinct, incompatible goals are what produce the tension players navigate.

Summary:

- *Three factions with conflicting goals force players to choose sides. Two factions create a coin flip*
- *Mark faction territory on the map: the borders between territories are where adventures happen*
- *Each faction needs one concrete next action: "what they'll do next" drives the campaign forward between sessions*

Step 6: Connect Everything

You have facts, terrain, history, settlements, and factions. They're sitting on the same map, but they might not be talking to each other yet. This step weaves them into a web.

Draw trade routes between settlements. Follow the paths of least resistance: river routes, valley roads, passes through barriers. Each route should carry something specific. Iron goes from Durath to the crossing town. Timber goes from the eastern settlements to the coast. Place your most interesting encounters along these lines. They're the paths players will travel most often.

Now look at each hex and ask whether it references at least one neighbor. The watchtower in hex 0405 should watch over something in 0404 or 0505. The bandit camp should sit on a trade route. The abandoned shrine should belong to the same culture that built the ruins two hexes north. Every hex that points to another hex gives players a reason to keep moving.

That said, not everything needs to connect. A strange idol in an empty clearing, a sealed door in a hillside with no path leading to it, a skeleton clutching a letter addressed to no one you've heard of. Some discoveries are powerful precisely because they stand alone. They reward the players who wander off the trade routes and poke into corners. The isolated find becomes memorable because it's the one thing on the map that doesn't explain itself through connections. Use these sparingly, one or two per region, so they stay special.

For everything else, isolation is a dead end. Apply the logic test: pick any element and ask whether a local resident could explain why it exists. If the answer requires GM-only knowledge, rewrite it until a farmer could give a reason.

Read through your material and find connections you didn't plan. The burned village from your history and the bandit camp from your encounter notes might be the same story. The drought from your three facts and the mud-clogged crossing from your settlement note might share a cause. These discovered connections feel more organic than engineered ones. This network of cross-references is what I call an implication web: every element on the map implies at least one other, and players can pull on any thread to find more.

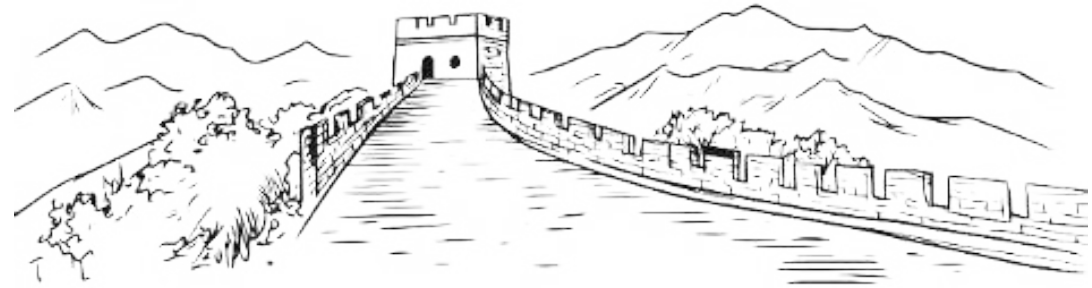
In my experience, each keyed hex works best when it points to at least one neighboring hex. The bandit camp notes mention where the crew hides between raids. The river crossing notes reference the town downstream. These pointers turn separate locations into a connected region.

Failure mode: A region where every hex is self-contained produces a hexcrawl that plays like a random encounter table. Players clear a hex, move on, and never look back. Nothing compounds.

Summary:

- *Trade routes are the skeleton of your region: place your best content along them*
- *Every hex should reference at least one neighbor. Isolated hexes are dead ends*
- *One contested resource ties faction conflict to a physical location players can visit and change*

Each of these steps has a dedicated chapter later in the book (Chapters 2 through 7) with techniques for deepening your work. But you don't need any of that for your first session.



Worked Example: Building the Greymire

Let me walk you through the method applied to a single region, start to finish. I started with a simple idea: a marshy river lowland where old infrastructure's being reclaimed by nature and by people.

Step 1: Three Facts and a Twist

I named the region first: 'the Greymire.' A name gives you and your players something to call the place from session zero. Pick something evocative and short. You can always change it later.

Three facts about the Greymire:

1. Marshy lowlands are slowly reclaiming old farmland. The fields are still visible as rectangular shapes under the reeds, but nobody's worked them in living memory.
2. A single stone bridge over the River Asken controls all north-south trade. Whoever holds the bridge sets the toll.
3. A network of canals threads through the marshes. The builders (the Aulavarai) vanished centuries ago. The canals are clogged with mud and impassable.

The twist: the canals are flowing again. Silt is clearing from channels that've been dead for generations. Stone locks are groaning open without anyone working the mechanisms. Nobody agrees on why.

Step 2: Terrain Sketch

A 5-by-4 hex grid (20 hexes). Four core terrain types plus two special features:

- Marsh: 8 hexes
- Forested hills: 4 hexes
- River: 3 hexes
- Canal channels: 2 hexes
- Abandoned farmland: 2 hexes
- The bridge hex: 1 hex

Step 3: Three Ages of History

1. **The Aulavarai Period (centuries ago).** Canal builders with advanced water engineering who turned marsh into farmland. They left stone infrastructure and inscribed lock mechanisms, but no explanation for why they abandoned everything.
2. **The Collapse (generations ago).** The canals stopped, water spilled back across the lowlands, farmland reverted to marsh. Most people left. Those who stayed adapted: stilts, fishing, trapping, reeds.
3. **The Current Land-Grab (now).** The canals are reactivating. Land that's been underwater for generations is draining. Three groups see three different opportunities, and their goals are incompatible.

Step 4: Two Settlements

Bridgewatch (~200). Toll town at the bridge crossing.

- **Settlement note:** Location reason: only bridge crossing the Asken. Product: toll revenue, market access. Need: security (Maren's authority is possession, not law). Problem: canal reactivation threatens the bridge monopoly.

Stilton (~60). Deep marsh, accessible only by boat. The marsh folk know where the Aulavarai ruins are. Nobody else does.

- **Settlement note:** Location reason: deep marsh, accessible only by boat. Product: marsh knowledge, Aulavarai ruin locations. Need: isolation from outsiders. Problem: the marsh is draining and outsiders are coming.

Step 5: Three Factions

A frontier with 20 hexes doesn't need empires. It needs three groups who want incompatible things from the same patch of ground.

- **The Bridge Warden** (Maren Holt). Controls the bridge, collects tolls. She wants the canals to stay broken because functioning canals would bypass her monopoly. Pragmatic, fair with tolls, ruthless about competition.

- **The Reclaimers.** Fifteen settlers led by a scholar named Drest who wants to reopen the canals and establish farms. They have partial knowledge of Aulavarai engineering, enough to be dangerous, not enough to be safe.
- **The Marsh Folk of Stilton.** Led by an elder named Pell. They don't want the canals reopened. They also know something the others don't: the mechanisms are activating on their own, and they aren't purely water-powered. Pell has seen lights in the old locks at night.

Step 6: Connections

The trade route crosses the bridge north-south. Maren controls it.

The canal network connects to Aulavarai ruins in the deep marsh. Everyone knows the ruins exist from old stories, but their exact locations in the trackless marsh are Stilton's closely guarded secret. If reopened, the canals would bypass the bridge. Drest wants this. Maren fears it.

The contested resource is the bridge itself short-term, and the land under the marsh long-term. All three factions need different things from the same geography.

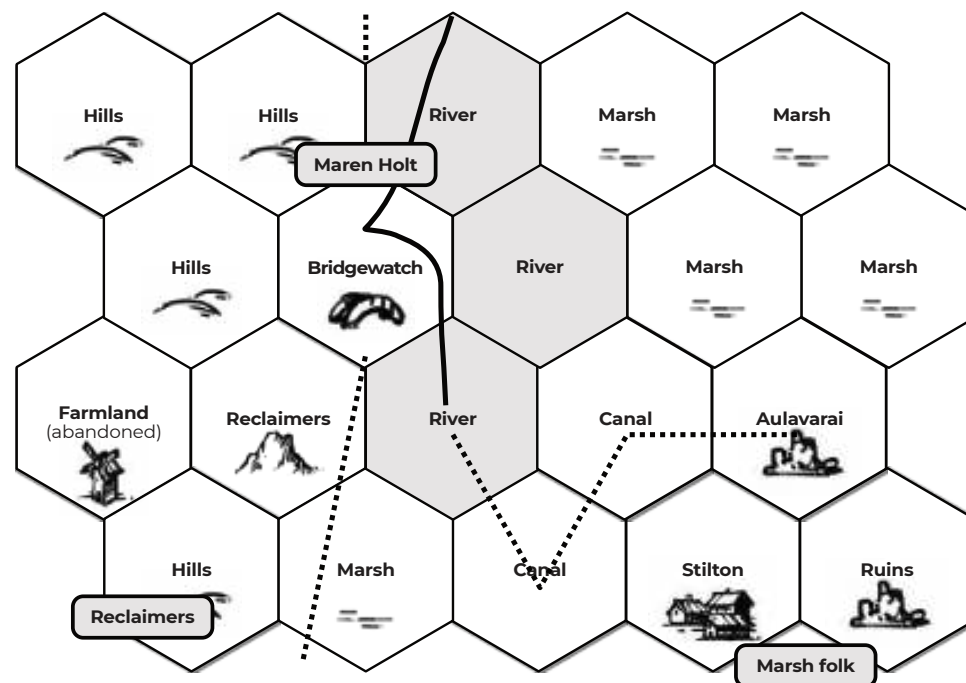
The mystery (why are the canals reactivating?) connects to ruins only the marsh folk can find. Any faction that wants answers needs Stilton's cooperation, and Stilton isn't cooperating.

Total prep time: one evening. The Greymire is ready to play.

In session two, the party hired a Stilton marsh guide to reach an Aulavarai ruin Drest had marked. Halfway through a canal, the boat's wake set a stone lock grinding beneath the water. The guide went pale and turned back. Drest, when asked, was excited. That moment gave me the three-way tension: the marsh folk know something is wrong, the Reclaimers see an opportunity, and the party is caught between fear and ambition. The scene emerged from connections I'd already written into the map.

The Greymire: Worked Example

5 x 4 hex grid, 20 hexes



The Greymire: Terrain, settlements, factions, and history on one map

River Asken flows north to south. Total prep: ca. 90 min.

You now have a playable region, ready for session one. Everything after this point is optional. The rest of the book is a toolbox for making a good region better, organized around the things you actually prep. Browse by need, skip what doesn't apply, come back when an element isn't pulling its weight.

CHAPTER 2

THE TERRAIN CARD

Terrain is the first thing that shapes player decisions. Before factions or history enter play, the land itself tells players where they can go, what it costs, and what they risk.

This chapter covers everything about terrain: from initial placement to seasonal variation. Each section builds on the one before it, so your terrain grows richer as your campaign does.



BUILD: Draw the Land

In Chapter 1, Step 2, you drew your terrain with three to four types, barriers, and borders. You made four decisions in order:

- *Where water flows*
- *Where barriers sit*
- *What terrain types fill the spaces between*
- *And where those terrains transition into each other*

That's your terrain foundation. The sections below show how to deepen it when travel starts feeling samey or when you want terrain to drive harder decisions.

DEEPEN: Barriers and Chokepoints

A mountain range across the middle of your map does more for game-play than fifty hexes of detailed terrain. It divides the map into two zones with different cultures, factions, and dangers. Players crossing that range commit to a journey. They leave one political reality and enter another.

Rivers, mountain chains, dense forests, and deserts all serve as natural borders. But the interesting part isn't the wall. It's the door. A single pass through a mountain range becomes the most important hex on your map. Whoever controls that pass controls trade, migration, and military access between two regions.

Place your best content at these transition points: the ancient bridge, the fortified pass, the ferry crossing, the forest gate. A three-room dungeon at a mountain pass generates more play than a twenty-room dungeon on a featureless plain, because the pass matters to every faction on both sides. In the Greymire, the bridge hex shows this principle in action, channeling three factions' competing interests into one crossing.

My approach: identify three to five natural barriers on your map, then place one significant location (fort, bridge, pass, or gate) at each crossing point.

At the table, it plays like this. The party needs to reach the valley on the other side of the mountains. There are two options: a three-day detour south to the lowland crossing, or a one-day climb through a narrow pass held by a garrison that charges a toll and asks questions. The fighter wants to bluff through the pass. The rogue wants to avoid the garrison entirely. That argument is the barrier doing its job. Without it, they'd walk east in a straight line and arrive without a decision.

DEEPEN: Terrain Profiles

If forest hexes and grassland hexes play the same way, one of them is dead weight. Every terrain type should change how players make decisions.

For each terrain type, write down four things:

- *Movement cost*
- *Primary danger*
- *Available resource*
- *Visibility range*

I recommend building this profile for every terrain type before your first session. If two terrains share all four answers, merge them or change one. Four distinct types that each play differently beat eight types that blur together. Movement speed, resources, danger, and visibility should all shift when the party crosses a terrain boundary.

A day has four six-hour watches: morning, afternoon, evening, and night. *Book 1* covers the full exploration turn. Example:

Dense Forest.

- **Movement cost:** *2 watches per hex (half the speed of open ground).*
- **Primary danger:** *ambush, getting lost.*
- **Available resource:** *timber, game, herbs.*
- **Visibility range:** *one hex (can't see landmarks from inside the canopy).*

Open Grassland.

- **Movement cost:** *1 watch per hex.*
- **Primary danger:** *exposure, no cover from weather or enemies.*
- **Available resource:** *grazing, foraging, clear sightlines.*
- **Visibility range:** *three hexes (flat terrain reveals landmarks and approaching threats).*

Mountains.

- **Movement cost:** *3 watches per hex (steep terrain, frequent dead ends).*
- **Primary danger:** *falls, rockslides, altitude sickness.*
- **Available resource:** *ore, defensible positions, mountain springs.*
- **Visibility range:** *varies (blind in valleys, enormous from ridgelines).*

The available resource gives players a reason to enter difficult terrain on purpose. If the forest offers nothing the party needs, it's just an obstacle. If it has rare herbs that cure a disease spreading in town, crossing it becomes a decision, not a detour.

Resources are one reason to enter a hex. Ruins (Chapter 5) give players mysteries and rewards hidden in the landscape. Wildlife (Chapter 7) gives them predators to hunt and prey to track. A contested faction resource (Chapter 4) gives them something worth fighting over. Each of these makes the map itself valuable to explore, not just a grid to move across.

Limit your map to five terrain types maximum (the three to four from your initial build plus one more if a technique in this chapter calls for it). Give each type a one-line gameplay summary you keep behind your screen during play. The Greymire has four core types (marsh, forested hills, river, abandoned farmland) with two special features (canal channels and the bridge hex) layered on top, each with distinct movement costs and faction presence.

DEEPEN: Seasonal Effects

This technique works best after you've run two or three sessions and noticed players always taking the same route. Don't add seasons during your initial build.

A static map is a solved puzzle. Once players learn the terrain, the optimal route becomes fixed. Seasons break that pattern. The same hex plays differently in winter than in summer, keeping the map interesting even after repeated crossings.

Two seasons work for most campaigns: a good season and a bad season.

The transition changes which routes are passable, which resources are available, and which threats are active. Mountain passes close under snow. Rivers flood in the wet season and become shallow enough to cross in the dry. Bandits raid during harvest. Two seasons works for any climate. Monsoon and dry season. Fire season and growth season. Frozen and melting. A desert campaign might split the year into burning days and freezing nights, or sandstorm months and clear months. Pick whatever pair creates the biggest change in how your map plays.

When the mountain pass closes for winter, the lowland crossing becomes the only way across, and whoever holds the crossing sets the terms. The same geography that shuts down one route hands players a new power to contest.

In the Greymire, the seasonal change is the gradual reactivation of ancient canals, transforming the marsh from a barrier into a navigable highway.

You don't need to change every hex. One significant seasonal effect per region keeps the calendar relevant without creating a logistics nightmare. The northern mountains are impassable in winter. The river valley floods in spring. The southern plains burn in late summer. Three changes across three regions give players enough to plan around.

Book 1 tracks time in watches and days. For seasons to matter, you also need a calendar. It doesn't need to be elaborate. Number the weeks. When you reach week 12, winter hits. Mark the current week on your *GM sheet* at the start of each session. That's enough to make seasons, deadlines, and faction timelines work.

In my games, I pick one dramatic seasonal change per region and announce it to players at the start of each season so they can factor it into their plans.

The Terrain Card

Copy this card for each terrain type and fill it in as your campaign develops. The BUILD row gets filled before session one. The DEEPEN rows get filled when travel starts feeling flat or when you want the terrain to push harder.

The Terrain Card

Terrain Type: _____

Build (before session 1)

Hex coverage : _____

Key barriers : _____

Checkpoint locations : _____

Deepen (when travel feels flat)

Movement cost : _____

Primary danger : _____

Available resource : _____

Visibility range : _____

Good season effect : _____

Bad season effect : _____

CHAPTER 3

THE SETTLEMENT CARD

Settlements are where players resupply, gather rumors, and make allies. They're also the places most likely to feel generic if you haven't written down the right details.

This chapter collects everything you need for settlements in one place: the foundation you build before session one, the cultural details you add when a settlement starts feeling thin, and the two-line upkeep that keeps it alive between sessions.



BUILD: Settle the People

In Chapter 1, Step 4, you wrote four things per settlement:

- *Location reason*
- *What it produces*
- *What it needs*
- *Its current problem*

Those four entries give you everything required to run the settlement during play. When players ask questions you haven't prepared for, improvise from them. The sections below show how to deepen settlements when they start feeling generic.

DEEPEN: Culture From the Ground Up

The most believable cultures in a hexcrawl grow from the terrain they inhabit. Start with three questions about the environment. What does it provide in abundance? What does it lack? What does it threaten? From those three answers you can derive diet, architecture, economy, social values, and religion, all without inventing culture from scratch. You're deriving it from the map you already drew.

Example: *A settlement sits on a river delta in a humid marshland. What does the environment provide? Fish, reeds, clay. What does it lack? Stone, metal, high ground. What does it threaten? Flooding, disease, isolation. From those answers: the people eat smoked fish and reed-flour bread. They build with mud-and-reed walls on stilts. They value self-reliance (because help is far away) and fear the annual flood. Their taboo is wasting food, because surplus is what gets them through flood season.*

Once you've answered the three environmental questions, lock the culture down in five details that'll cover the first hour of play: What they eat, how they greet strangers, what they value, what's taboo, and what the buildings look like.

Write these on a single card per settlement. This five-detail card is the single best prep-to-play ratio I've found for settlements. That's your entire cultural reference sheet.

Example card:

Stilthaven (river delta)

- **Food:** smoked catfish, reed cakes, pickled roots
- **Greeting:** a child rows out in a skiff to inspect newcomers before anyone speaks
- **Value:** give-and-take (you eat, you work)
- **Taboo:** entering a house without removing your shoes (tracks mud into living spaces built over water)
- **Architecture:** grass-roofed houses on wooden stilts, connected by rope bridges, no ground-level doors

Food is the most immediate sensory detail. Smoked goat and root mash tells a different story than river trout and rice wine. Values and taboos create tension: if the party accidentally violates a taboo, the consequences are immediate and social. Players learn the taboo by breaking it, which is more memorable than being told.

A fighter in heavy boots clomps into the elder's stilt-house without thinking. The room goes silent. Children are ushered out. The elder asks the party to leave and return *'when you understand where you are.'* The party hasn't started a fight. They've started a social problem that costs them access to the settlement's knowledge and trade until they make amends. One broken taboo generated three sessions of consequences.

Architecture is the visual shortcut. *"Stone walls with painted shutters"* is the entire cultural reference a settlement needs at the table.

When players surprise you with cultural questions you haven't prepped, improvise from the card. *'Would they trade with strangers?'* is answered by the outsider stance. *'Do they worship any gods?'* is answered by their taboo. The five details give you enough to triangulate anything.

DEEPEN: The Outsider's View

Every culture has a default response to strangers, and it's the first thing your players experience. Define it before you define anything else.

What works for me: assign every settlement one of four stances before the first session. Four common stances cover most situations:

Stance	First scene	NPC Behavior
Suspicion	A guard intercepts the party at the edge of town	Locals watch closely, limit access, expect the party to leave soon
Hospitality	A child runs up and leads the party to the elder's house	Locals offer food and shelter, but expect something in return, or departure
Exploitation	A merchant approaches with overpriced supplies and a wide smile	Every interaction has a price. Locals see strangers as customers or marks
Indifference	The party wanders in and nobody looks up	Strangers are irrelevant unless they cause trouble or offer something useful

Note each settlement's stance alongside its other entries. *The Settlement Card* at the end of this chapter has a field for it. Stances vary by settlement, not by culture. Two villages from the same culture might have different stances: one is a crossroads town used to traders (exploitation), while the other is a remote hamlet that rarely sees strangers (suspicion). The stance reflects the settlement's specific experience with outsiders. Spend five seconds per settlement. This tiny investment means you'll never have to improvise a town's first impression from nothing, which is the moment where most GMs fall back on generic fantasy innkeeper behavior.

In the Greymire, Stilton starts as suspicion. A voice calls from the reeds asking who sent them, and the party waits in their boat until the elder decides whether they land. Three sessions later, after the party warned Stilton about Reclaimer survey teams pushing into the deep marsh, the elder Pell met them at the dock herself. The stance had shifted to cautious hospitality, and with it came access: Pell offered a guide to the deep-marsh ruins. That shift, earned through action rather than persuasion rolls, gave the players their first real lead on the canal mystery.

MAINTAIN: Between Sessions

After each session, note any change in an NPC's attitude toward the players: the direction of the shift and what caused it.

Flag approaching seasonal changes that would affect settlement resources or problems. Two lines per settlement, two minutes of work.

The Settlement Card

SETTLEMENT: _____

Build (before session 1)

Location reason : _____
Produces : _____
Needs : _____
Current problem : _____

Deepen (when it feels generic)

Food : _____
Greeting : _____
Value : _____
Taboo : _____
Architecture : _____

Outsider stance (one of)

Suspicion Hospitality
Exploitation Indifference

Maintain (between sessions)

NPC attitude shift : _____
Seasonal resource change : _____



CHAPTER 4

THE FACTION CARD

Factions make the world feel alive. They move, they clash, they react to the party.

This chapter covers everything about factions in one place: building them before session one, deepening them with physical evidence, and maintaining them between sessions.



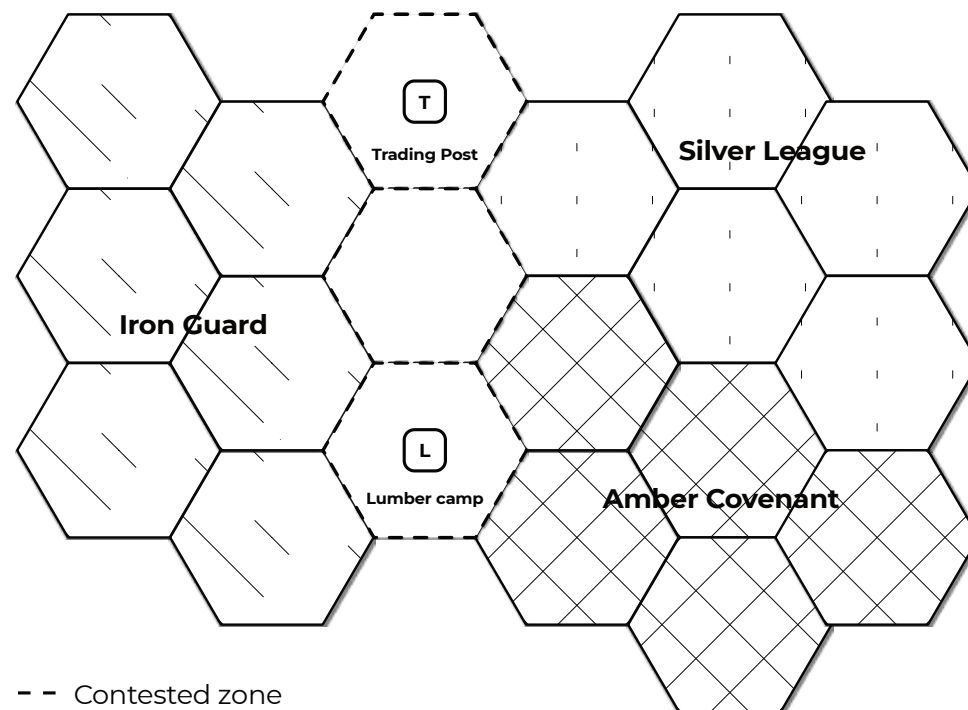
BUILD: Set the Factions

In Chapter 1, Step 5, you created three factions:

- *Identity*
- *Goal*
- *Next action*
- *Territory*
- A named NPC each

Mark faction territory on your map with color-coding or symbols. The borders between territories are your most interesting hexes. The sections below show how to make factions visible in the world and how to keep them moving between sessions.

Faction Territory Map



-- Contested zone

□ Location adventures concentrate here

DEEPEN: Faction Traces

Factions exist whether the party interacts with them or not. The question is how players learn about factions, and the answer should be physical evidence, not NPC monologues.

Faction traces are the marks a faction leaves on the landscape. Boot prints on a trail that's supposed to be abandoned. A dead horse bearing an unfamiliar brand. A symbol scratched into a tree at eye height. Cargo that fell from a wagon and was never retrieved. Each trace gives players a fragment. Multiple fragments build a picture.

Supernatural factions leave different marks. A dead-worship cult might leave animal bones arranged in patterns at crossroads. A fey court's territory shows impossible growth: flowers blooming in winter, trees fruiting out of season. A dragon's influence zone has scorched clearings and the smell of sulfur near water sources. Magical traces work the same way as mundane ones: fragments that build a picture over multiple encounters.

I recommend listing three traces per active faction: one common (found in multiple hexes), one uncommon (found near faction operations), and one rare (found only at faction bases or after significant events).

Place traces by distance from the faction's base. Common traces spread across the whole territory, so put them on your encounter table. Uncommon traces cluster near active faction operations. Rare traces sit at faction bases or key sites. Distance from base tracks rarity, and the faction-trace diagram shows the gradient.

If you need a quick prompt while improvising, roll 2d6:

- **2-7:** Common
- **8-9:** Uncommon
- **10-11:** Rare
- **12:** The faction itself (a patrol, an envoy, a scout, caught mid-action)

This is a prompt, not a rule. Override the roll when the fiction points somewhere specific.

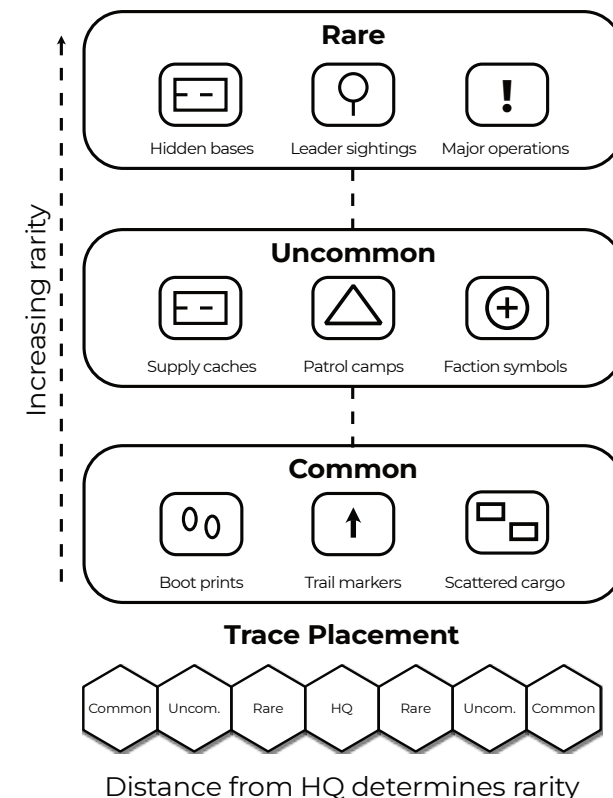
Ironveil Company:

- **Common:** toll receipts nailed to bridge posts.
- **Uncommon:** a supply cache beneath a marked bridge piling.
- **Rare:** a burned barge still smoldering with Ironveil cargo aboard.

Traces should be interpretable but ambiguous. Boot prints tell the party that armed people travel this path regularly. They don't tell the party who those people are or what they want. A scratched symbol identifies a faction only if the party's seen that symbol before. Build recognition over time. The first symbol is nothing. The third is familiar. The fifth is a warning: this is faction territory, and the people who marked these trees don't want visitors.

Faction Trace Escalation

Players discover factions through physical clues, not exposition



MAINTAIN: The World Moves Without the Party

Your hexcrawl world isn't a stage set that resets between scenes. Factions pursue goals. Seasons change resources. The party is one actor among many.

The system is minimal. Write one sentence per faction per session describing their current action. *"The miners push deeper into the silver vein."*
"The druids sabotage the east road."

At the start of each session, check these sentences. Has time passed? Has the party interfered? If not, advance the action one step. If the party intervened, update accordingly. One sentence per faction, checked once per session.

Advancing means the faction takes the next logical step toward their goal. If the miners were digging last session, this session they've hit a new vein and are hiring guards. If the druids were sabotaging roads, this session they've escalated to poisoning a well that serves a logging camp. If a cult was gathering followers, this session they've built a hidden shrine in the forest. Each advance makes the faction more visible and harder to ignore.

Supernatural factions advance differently. A haunting spreads from one ruin to an adjacent hex. A sleeping dragon's influence grows as its dreams intensify, warping wildlife in a widening circle. Track these the same way: one sentence, checked once per session.

Don't track more than five factions this way. Five is enough to create the illusion of a world in motion. More than five becomes bookkeeping, and bookkeeping kills the practice. Appendix B's between-session checklist provides the exact steps for reviewing and updating these faction sentences.

Players don't need to see the world move. They need to see that it has moved. The evidence of change (new fortifications, shifted borders, a burned bridge, a new face in a familiar tavern) communicates a living world more effectively than any narration. Describe the result, not the process.

In one of my campaigns, the party spent two sessions exploring ruins in the east. When they returned to the bridge town, a Reclaimer flag was flying from the toll post and the old toll keeper was gone. Nobody explained what happened. The party pieced it together from a nervous innkeeper and a discarded letter. That ten-second description at the start of the session did more for the world feeling alive than anything I'd narrated in months.

The Faction Card

FACTION: _____

Build (before session 1)

Identity : _____

Goal : _____

Next action : _____

Territory : _____

Named NPC : _____

Deepen (when factions feel invisible)

Common trace : _____

Uncommon trace : _____

Rare trace : _____

Maintain (between sessions)

This week's action : _____

Status change : _____

CHAPTER 5

THE RUIN CARD

Ruins are the hexcrawl's best hooks. Players spot them from a distance, approach with questions, and leave with more questions than they arrived with.

A crumbling watchtower on a ridge is visible, explorable, and worth the detour. This chapter consolidates everything you need to make ruins pull their weight: placing them during the build, deepening them for play, and a card format that keeps prep fast.



BUILD: Place the Evidence

In Chapter 1, Step 3, you placed physical evidence for each age of history:

- One ruin per age
- One old road
- Two landscape scars

That's your ruin foundation: a mark on the map and a sentence about what era it came from. The sections below show how to make ruins worth exploring.

DEEPEN: Ruins as Questions, Not Answers

A museum explains itself. A ruin raises questions. Structure every ruin around three elements: one fact, one clue, and one mystery.

The fact: what players determine on sight. This was a watchtower. The walls are dwarven stonework. It burned. Without a fact, the ruin is just scenery.

The clue: physical evidence implying why the ruin exists in its current state. Scorch marks climb the interior walls but not the exterior: the fire started inside. The door was barricaded from within. Good clues are specific and visual. "Something bad happened here" isn't a clue. "The chairs are stacked against the east window and the glass is intact" is a clue.

The mystery: the piece you leave unanswered. What were they watching for? What started the interior fire? Why does the stonework predate the kingdom that claims to have built it? When players discover a ruin's mystery, have at least two possible resolutions prepared. The watchtower might have been watching for something from the mountains, or it might have been watching its own kingdom for signs of rebellion. Leave the answer open until the players engage with it. Then connect the resolution to whatever they find most interesting, or to a faction that needs leverage. Mysteries that stay flexible are mysteries that stay useful.

If you can't fill all three (fact, clue, mystery), the ruin isn't ready for play.

What I do: write a fact/clue/mystery card for every ruin on my map during prep. It takes thirty seconds each and saves me from improvising hollow ruins during play. *Book 2* covers encounter design principles that apply to any location, including ruins.

DEEPEN: Ruin Ecology

Ruins don't stay empty. The moment people leave, something else arrives. What moves in tells your players two things: how long ago people left, and what resources the ruin still offers.

The timeline is predictable. In the first months, scavengers pick through anything edible. Rats, ravens, and foxes. In the first years, opportunistic denizens move in: bandits who want walls, or animals that want shelter. A wolf pack denning in a collapsed hall tells players this ruin fell within a generation. Within decades, the structure itself becomes habitat. Trees root in cracked foundations. Bats colonize upper floors. The ruin is becoming terrain.

The shortcut that works: assign each ruin a single word. Recent, occupied, or reclaimed. Recent means scavengers and intact contents. Occupied means intelligent squatters and mixed contents. Reclaimed means wildlife and structural decay. That single word sets the tone for everything players find inside.

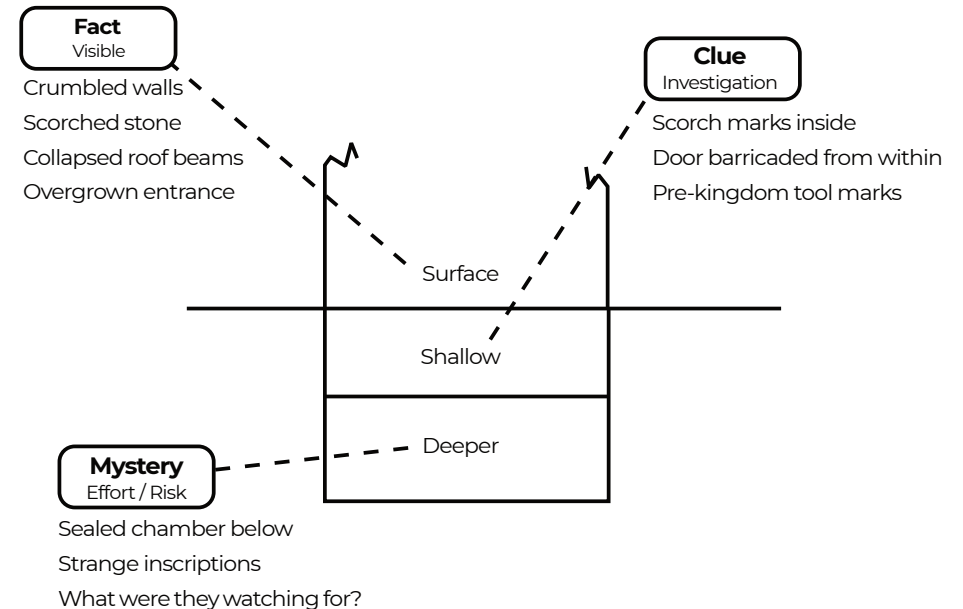
The same ruin tells three different stories depending on when it fell. Take a stone watchtower:

- **Recent (abandoned months ago):** *Rats in the larder, a cold fire pit, a journal left on the table, food stores half-eaten. Something drove the garrison out in a hurry.*
- **Occupied (abandoned years ago):** *A bandit crew has moved in. They've patched the roof with hide, barricaded the ground floor, and hung stolen goods from the rafters. The original furnishings are firewood.*
- **Reclaimed (abandoned decades ago):** *Ivy covers the walls. A fox den occupies the ground floor. The upper story is open to the sky, and a young oak grows through the collapsed roof. Only the foundation stones reveal this was ever a building.*

The occupant-as-clue principle works here. Players who find a ruin full of goblins can ask: why goblins? They moved in because the ruin's defensible and near water. They stay because something larger drove them from their previous home. The goblins aren't the story. They're evidence of a larger story, and the thing that displaced them is still out there.

Ruin Discovery Layers

A crumbled watchtower with three tiers of information



Each layer of investigation rewards deeper questions

The Ruin Card

Ruin: _____

Build (before session 1)

Era	:	_____
Visible fact	:	_____

Deepen (when ruins need depth)

Clue (evidence)	:	_____
Mystery (question)	:	_____
Possible resolution 1	:	_____
Possible resolution 2	:	_____
Current inhabitants	:	_____

Ecology state (one of)

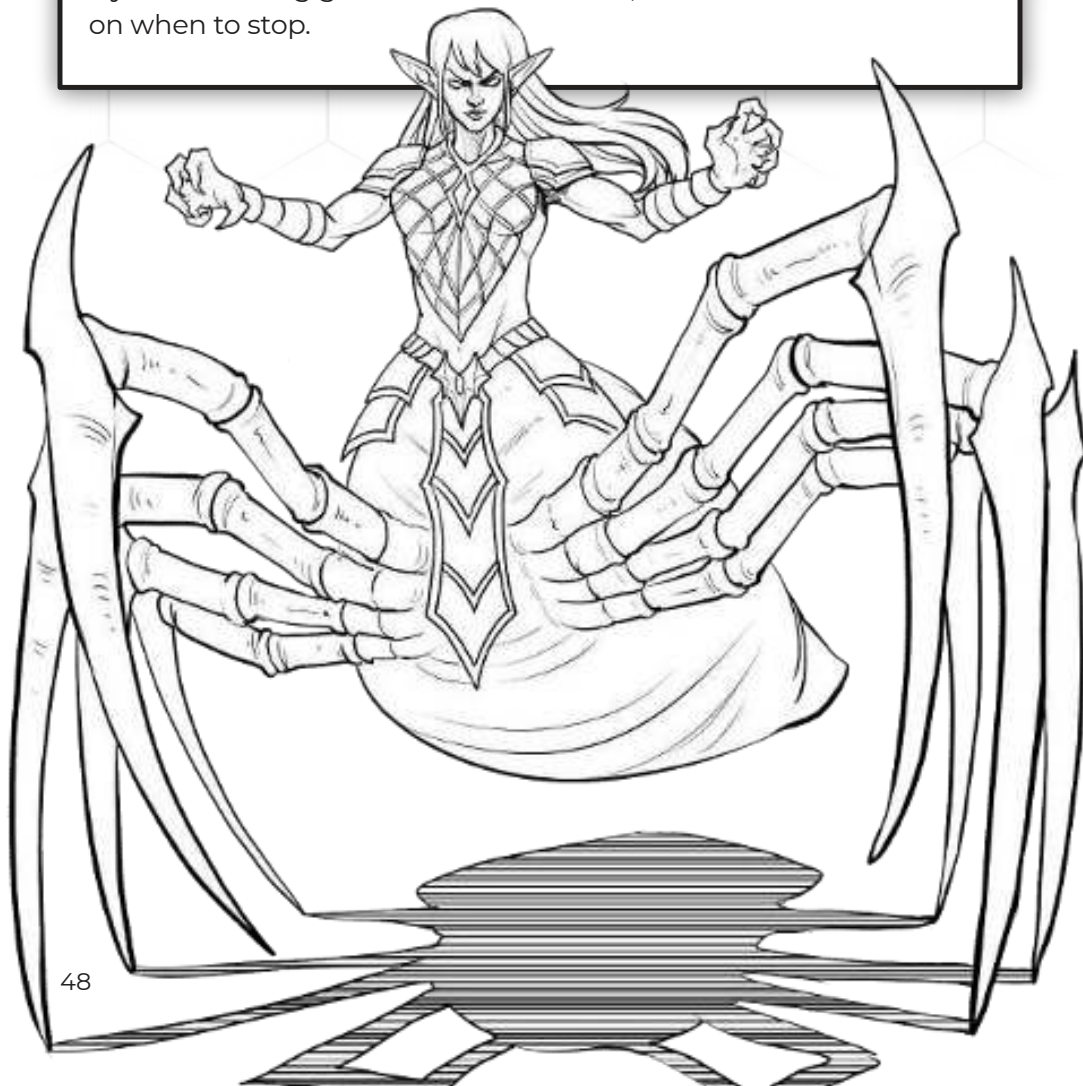
Recent	Occupied	Reclaimed
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CHAPTER 6

HISTORY AND CONTEXT

History in a hexcrawl lives in the ground, not in a textbook. Players discover what came before through ruins, names, and scars in the landscape.

This chapter covers how to deepen your region's past, from hidden layers to naming guides to dead factions, and includes a hard rule on when to stop.



BUILD: Facts, Ages, and Connections

In Chapter 1, you established:

- *Three facts and a twist (Step 1)*
- *Defined three ages of history with physical evidence (Step 3)*
- *Wove connections between every element (Step 6).*

That's your historical foundation. Enough to run a campaign on. The sections below show how to deepen that history when players start asking questions your six sentences don't answer.

DEEPEN: The Layered Map

Players feel the depth of a world through a layered map. The current world sits on top of older worlds, and traces of those older worlds bleed through everywhere: an old road under a new one, a settlement built on older foundations, a border that follows a forgotten wall.

Pick three major features (a road, a settlement, and a border) and write one sentence about what each replaced. That single sentence per feature gives you enough depth for months of play.

Start with infrastructure. The stone bridge in hex 0304 has carved faces on its supports that don't match any local tradition. That's because the current people didn't build it. An older culture did, and their sacred symbols still mark the foundations. When a player recognizes those same symbols on a ruin three hexes north, they've just connected two pieces of history through observation. That connection didn't come from a lore dump. It came from walking across a bridge and paying attention.

The best layered map I ever prepped was a fishing village built inside a drained reservoir. Every session, players noticed another detail that didn't fit a village's history. The village well was perfectly circular and lined with glazed brick, far too sophisticated for a fishing village. And every basement in town had the same dark line on the walls at exactly the same height, marking where the water used to reach when this was still a reservoir. Both details gave the players pieces of a puzzle they hadn't known existed.

DEEPEN: Reading the Land

Your map already contains history you never placed there. A flat-topped hill in rough terrain suggests something leveled it: a fort, a quarry, a ritual platform. A straight line of trees crossing open grassland marks an old road or property boundary. A circular lake with steep banks implies an explosion, a collapse, or an excavation. You drew the terrain. The history's already embedded in the shapes.

In my games, I start by circling five landforms that look artificial or unusual and writing a one-sentence historical explanation for each.

Sit with your map for a few minutes and look for oddities. Where does terrain change abruptly? Where does a feature seem too regular to be natural? Each oddity is a historical question you can answer whenever you like. The straight ridge between two valleys might be a natural formation, or an ancient dam. You don't need to decide until a player walks up and starts looking closely. Real geography provides endless inspiration:

- **Flat-topped hill in rough terrain:** *A buried temple complex, hidden under millennia of soil.*
- **Arc of sinkholes following a curved line:** *The rim of a buried crater. Something massive struck here long ago.*
- **Artificial mound with no obvious purpose:** *A monument whose meaning was lost, or a sealed vault.*
- **Young forest covering what should be old-growth:** *A vanished civilization cleared the land, and the forest hasn't recovered fully.*

These oddities are also perfect locations for supernatural rewards. A buried temple might house a wraith that guards a relic. The crater rim could concentrate old power drawn into the stone. The sealed mound might contain enchanted tools from a dead civilization. When players learn that landscape oddities sometimes point to magical treasures or dangerous lairs underground, they start reading the map with real hunger. Keep a second column blank for alternative explanations. When players investigate, pick whichever version creates the better session.

Subversion keeps the technique alive. Sometimes reward players who read the land. Other times, break the pattern. The straight tree line is natural, an effect of the underground water table. This prevents landscape-reading from becoming a solved puzzle.

DEEPEN: Names as Fossils

Every place name on your map is a piece of compressed history. Real-world place names preserve languages that vanished centuries ago. Your fictional names can do the same work for zero prep cost.

Name	What it reveals
Ashford	A crossing, and something burned
King's Grave	Someone important died here, or someone wanted you to think so
Stillwater	A water feature changed its flow
Ironhold	A resource and a fortification
Dragonmere	A lake with a legend attached

Notice what those names have in common. Each is built from two or three plain-English pieces stuck together. Ashford is ash plus ford. Ironhold is iron plus hold. A descriptor attached to a landscape feature gives you a name that carries its history in two words. That's one technique.

A consistent sound palette is the second. When players cross from one cultural region into another, the place names should shift in sound. One culture uses hard consonants and short vowels. Another favors long syllables and soft sounds. That auditory border does more worldbuilding in five seconds than a page of cultural description.

What I do: build a six-word naming guide per culture. Three example words and three banned sounds. *"Karath, Dunmor, Veshk. No L, no soft TH, no double vowels."* This takes thirty seconds and gives you enough to improvise consistent names for both places and people during play.

Names also record events the current inhabitants have forgotten. *"Dragonfields"* might sit in a region where nobody's seen a dragon in living memory. The name persists because names are conservative. People keep using them long after the original meaning fades. Every fossilized name is a hook. A player who hears *"Dragonfields"* and asks *"why?"* has just handed you an adventure.

DEEPEN: Dead Factions and Living Consequences

Dead factions are the safest worldbuilding tool you have. A collapsed empire can't contradict your future plans. It can't act in ways you didn't intend. It sits in the ground, inert, generating consequences that drive current conflict.

Define one dead faction per region. Give it three legacies: something it built, something it broke, and something it left behind. The Serathi Empire built the road network (still used), broke the old tribal boundaries (creating current border disputes), and left behind sealed vaults (containing things the current powers want). Three sentences. Months of material.

The broken legacy explains current conflict. Whatever the dead faction disrupted (borders, religions, alliances) left a wound the current world is still negotiating. Two villages claim the same holy site because the empire relocated one village's population three centuries ago. Players who uncover the cause gain leverage in the dispute.

Define one dead faction before your campaign starts. Write three bullet points: built, broke, left behind. The left-behind legacy provides adventure hooks directly: sealed vaults, cursed artifacts, dormant constructs, unfinished rituals. Players aren't exploring a random cave. They're opening something the Serathi sealed for a reason.

Here's what this looks like at the table. The party finds a stone marker with an unfamiliar script. Two sessions later, they see the same script on a bridge foundation in a different hex. The wizard asks: *"Is this the same language as that marker?"* Yes. Now they're tracking a dead civilization across the map without you saying a word about it. By the time they find the sealed vault, they already have theories about who built it and why. The dead faction did all that work for you.

How Much History Is Too Much

This section is your guardrail. The techniques above add depth. This one tells you when to stop.

You've got too much history when your notes describe events no player will ever discover. Open your history document. Point to a fact. Ask: does this change what the party finds in a hex?

If the answer's no, you have three options before you cut it:

- **Attach it to a ruin.** Turn the historical fact into physical evidence in a specific hex. If the Serathi Empire conducted ritual sacrifices, place a stained altar in a ruin.
- **Give it to a faction.** Let a current faction claim, distort, or weaponize the historical fact. If the old empire had a legal code, one faction uses it to justify land claims.
- **Make it a rumor.** Compress the fact into a one-sentence rumor an NPC can deliver.

If none of those three work, the history genuinely isn't earning its place. Archive it.

The 60-second summary test catches the problem early. Summarize your region's history aloud in one minute. If you can't, you've got more history than your hexcrawl can deliver. Players encounter your world in fragments across dozens of sessions. They'll never sit for a lecture. Every piece of history must survive being delivered as a three-sentence rumor, a single inscription, or a visual detail in a ruin.

I recommend setting a hard limit of one page of history per region. If a fact can't earn its place on that page, try the three techniques above to make it relevant. If none work, archive it. Maybe it becomes relevant later. Probably it doesn't. When your page of history is dense with hooks, you'll spend every prep session for months pulling new material from it instead of inventing from scratch.

The Region History Card

Region: _____

Build (before session 1)

Three facts	:	_____
Twist	:	_____
Age 1 (what/why ended)	:	_____
Age 2 (what/why ended)	:	_____
Age 3 (what/why ended)	:	_____

Deepen (when history feels thin)

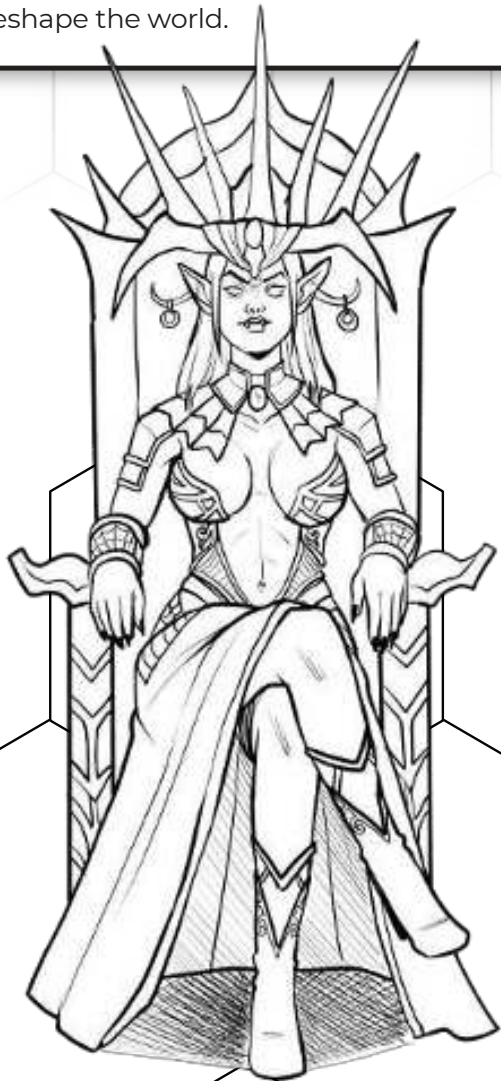
Hidden layer	:	_____
Oddity	:	_____
Naming guide (3+3)	:	_____

CHAPTER 7

GROWING AND CHANGING

Your region is built, sessions are running, and players are making choices you didn't predict.

This chapter covers what happens next. Wildlife that makes ecological sense, expanding beyond the edges of your map, and tracking how players reshape the world.



DEEPEN: Wildlife as Encounter Logic

Book 2 covered how to build encounters that create decisions. This technique adds another layer:

Stock your encounter tables by wildlife, not by arbitrary creature lists. When creatures on the table are connected by a food chain, encounters feel like the party walked into someone's territory.

Start with the top predator for each major terrain type. A forest with a wyvern at the top produces a different encounter table than one with a dire wolf pack. The wyvern needs large prey, open clearings, and a high roost. The dire wolves need pack territory, water sources, and herds to follow. Work down from the top predator. What does it eat? What do those creatures eat? What scavenges the kills? Each answer is an encounter table entry that arrived through logic instead of arbitrary selection.

In my experience, one top predator per terrain type is the right starting point. List four creatures connected by predation, competition, or scavenging. Here's how a simple food chain translates into encounter table entries (you'd fold these into a full encounter table as described in the Encounter Design Guidebook):

Encounter: Wyvern on the hunt

- *Deer herd, nervous and bunched*
- *Wolf pack trailing the herd*
- *Boar rooting in a clearing*
- *Trapper camp, drying hides*
- *Carrion pile, ravens squabbling over bones*
- *Fresh wolf tracks crossing a deer trail*
- *Wyvern roost on a crag, splintered bones below*

Add one intelligent faction (bandits, hunters, a hermit) and you've got entries that all belong in the same landscape.

Notice how most of these entries don't start with initiative. The wyvern attacks. The deer, wolves, boar, and trapper camp are signs, atmosphere, or a chance to talk. *Book 2's* 60/40 rule (at least sixty percent of your terrain encounter table should be non-combat) emerges naturally from wildlife logic: build the food chain first, and most of your encounters become non-combat by default.

DEEPEN: Expanding the Region

Sooner or later, your players will walk toward the edge of the map. That's a good problem. It means they're engaged enough to explore and confident enough to leave known territory.

The border hexes of your current region are the seeds for the next one. A river flowing south exits the map. That river goes somewhere. A mountain pass at the eastern boundary connects to a different climate, a different culture. The terrain at the edge is a promise, and the next region fulfills it. Start your three facts from what the current map already implies.

Carry forward one faction with cross-border interests, one history layer that extends beyond the map, and one terrain feature that continues into the new region.

My advice: build the next region when players enter the second-to-last row of hexes. That gives you some breathing room to prep the next region before players reach it. How much buffer depends on terrain and your group's pace. In open terrain, a party might cross three hexes in a day. In swamp or mountains, one hex could take all day. *Book 1's* travel rates give you the specifics. Use the six-step method from Chapter 1, but treat the border hexes as your starting constraints. The new region should take half the time because you already have anchors.

Stay one region ahead. Never more. Two regions beyond the players is wasted prep. The campaign will change direction, factions will shift, and those distant hexes will need rewriting. A region is the 20-to-30-hex area you built using Chapter 1's procedure. Each region has its own identity: shared terrain, connected factions, a central twist. When you build the next region, write one-sentence notes about its neighbors: 'The Ashlands to the south export obsidian and distrust lowlanders.' That sentence is enough until play moves that direction.

Expand up and down, not just sideways. The map has a third dimension. A cloud city tethered to a mountain peak, a cave network beneath the forest, a reef town off the coast: each is a region in its own right. Build them with the same six steps. Treat them as adjacent regions, with a vertical travel cost instead of a horizontal one.

The new region handles geography. But the wider world matters too, even the parts that will never appear on a hex map. The kingdom across the sea. The empire that collapsed centuries ago. The desert traders reference when explaining silk prices. These places exist as effects in your mapped region, not as fully built hexes.

My advice: define the world beyond by what it sends into your mapped region. Foreign trade goods along a specific road. Refugees settling in a border town. A religion sending missionaries north. Each is concrete, observable, and playable without building the source. Keep five or fewer off-map influences per region: a name, what it sends, and which settlement or faction it touches.

- **The Kestrani Empire** (*sends silk merchants via the east road, touches Bridgewatch*). *Valdris University* (*sends scholars seeking Aulavarai texts, touches the Reclaimer camp*). *The Fevered Shore* (*sends plague refugees, touches Stilton*)

Define off-map locations by what they send into your region (goods, refugees, missionaries, threats) rather than by their internal politics or geography.

MAINTAIN: When Players Change the World

Your players will change the world. They'll clear a dungeon, kill a faction leader, forge an alliance, burn a bridge, or build an outpost. They'll negotiate trade agreements, establish safe havens, and convince a hostile settlement to open its gates. These actions, destructive and constructive, are the point of play.

Player actions fall into four categories.

- **What they cleared:** *When players remove a threat, something else moves in. The bandits are gone from the watchtower. Now a merchant sets up shop, a rival predator claims the territory, or the local lord stations troops. Check your faction list. Whoever's closest and hungriest gets first claim.*
- **What they protected:** *Settlements or people the players defended remember. Protection creates loyalty, and loyalty becomes a resource: shelter, better prices, information freely given.*
- **What they angered:** *Factions that lose ground don't disappear. They retreat, regroup, and adapt. Enemies who survive become recurring problems, and recurring problems are the backbone of long campaigns.*
- **What they built:** *Players who establish a trading post, forge an alliance, or found a safe camp have created new infrastructure. That infrastructure attracts attention. The trading post draws merchants but also tax collectors. The alliance shifts the balance of power and other factions respond. The safe camp becomes a landmark that NPCs reference. Treat player-created locations as new keyed hexes with their own problems and opportunities.*

I recommend tracking four categories of player impact: what they cleared, what they protected, what they angered, and what they built. Spend ten minutes after each session updating one location that changed status, one faction that shifted position, and one NPC whose attitude moved.

The Growth Card

Region Growth: _____

Deepen (when the ecosystem needs logic)

Top predator	:	_____
What it hunts	:	_____
What prey eat	:	_____

Deepen (when players reach the edges)

Next region direction	:	_____
Carried faction	:	_____
Carried history	:	_____
Carried terrain	:	_____

Off-map influences:

1.	:	_____
2.	:	_____
3.	:	_____

Maintain (between sessions)

Cleared	:	_____
Protected	:	_____
Angered	:	_____
Built	:	_____

CHAPTER 8

MODIFYING YOUR EXISTING REGION

Many GMs will come to this book with a region already built. Maybe you've been running it for months. Maybe you built it years ago and it feels flat. This chapter helps you review what you have and patch the gaps.

Start by running through the *Build Checklist* in *Appendix B*.

Check each box honestly.

Most existing regions will pass on terrain and settlements but fail on connections and twists. That's normal. Those are the layers this book adds.



The Five-Minute Review

Pull out your map and your notes. Answer these questions:

- **Twist:** *Does your region have one? If every faction and settlement is stable and content, there's no engine driving play. Add a twist. Pick your most established fact and introduce something that doesn't fit. The peaceful kingdom has a new religion spreading through the border towns. The prosperous trade city's wells are going dry.*
- **Connections:** *Pick any hex. Does it reference at least one neighbor? If most of your hexes exist in isolation, spend an evening drawing connections. Trade routes between settlements. A ruin that relates to the watchtower three hexes south. A resource that two factions both need.*
- **Faction goals:** *Do your factions want incompatible things? If every faction's goal is "protect their territory," you have a static world. Give at least one faction an aggressive goal that forces the others to react.*
- **Physical history:** *Is your region's history visible on the map? If the past only exists in your notes, place three pieces of evidence: a ruin, an old road, a landscape scar. Connect them to current conflicts.*
- **Settlement problems:** *Does every settlement have a current problem that points elsewhere on the map? If not, add one per settlement. The problem doesn't need to be dramatic. "The well is running low and the nearest clean water is in contested territory" does the job.*

Worked Example: Reviewing the Ashwood

I ran this review on a region I'd built in a hurry for a campaign years ago. The Ashwood was a forest with a village, a bandit camp, and a dragon's lair. Functional, but flat. Here's what the review turned up:

- **Twist:** None. The forest was dangerous, the village was safe, the dragon was scary. Everything agreed with everything else. I added: "The village elder has been leaving offerings at the dragon's lair. The dragon hasn't attacked in twenty years. The bandits have."
- **Connections:** The bandit camp and the dragon's lair had no relationship. I drew a trade road through the forest and put the bandit camp on it. Now the bandits are intercepting offerings meant for the dragon, and the elder is getting nervous.
- **Faction goals:** The bandits wanted loot. The village wanted safety. Both defensive. I gave the bandits a real agenda: they think the dragon is dead and want to loot its hoard. Now the village and the bandits want incompatible things from the same lair.
- **Physical history:** Nothing on the map. I placed a burned clearing where an older village once stood (destroyed by the dragon a century ago) and an overgrown road connecting it to the current village. The current village exists because the old one was destroyed.
- **Settlement problems:** The village had no problem pointing elsewhere. I added: "Young people are leaving for the coast. The elder needs the party to prove the forest is safe enough to stay." Now the village's problem connects to the bandits, the dragon, and the larger world.

Total time: twenty minutes. The same region now has tension, connections, and three sessions of material I didn't have before.

Patching Specific Gaps

When your review identifies a weak area, this section tells you exactly which chapter addresses it. Match the symptom to the chapter, run the relevant technique, and your region is fixed in one prep session.

- **Region feels generic?** Add a twist (Step 1) and mark faction territory on the map (Step 5).
- **Travel feels monotonous?** Add barriers and differentiate your terrain types (Chapter 2).
- **World feels static?** Write one-sentence faction actions and advance them between sessions (Chapter 4).
- **Exploration feels unrewarding?** Layer history into your existing terrain (Chapter 6) and structure your ruins around fact, clue, and mystery (Chapter 5).
- **Settlements blur together?** Derive culture from terrain and assign outsider stances (Chapter 3).

Don't try to retrofit everything at once. Add a twist this week. Draw trade routes next week. Give each faction an action sentence the week after. In a month, your existing region will feel transformed, and you'll have done it in the margins of your normal prep time.

APPENDIX A:

COMMON PITFALLS

These failure modes were collected from throughout the book. They're organized by topic so you can scan the ones relevant to what you're working on.

General

Trying everything at once. You read every chapter, absorb dozens of techniques, and try to use them all at once. The region takes twenty hours instead of one evening, and you burn out before session one.

Building a continent instead of a region. You build a continent with two hundred hexes, each with a one-line description. Play starts and the players spend six sessions in the same five hexes. The other 195 gather dust. You feel like you wasted forty hours of prep, because you did.

Disconnected hexes. When every hex stands alone, each with its own creature, treasure, or NPC, players clear one, move on, and never return. Nothing builds across the map. The hexcrawl plays like a random encounter table. Fix: every hex should point to at least one other (Step 6).

Terrain

No barriers on the map. Maps without clear barriers produce a uniform soup of terrain where faction borders feel arbitrary and travel direction doesn't matter. Players pick the shortest path every time because the map gives them no reason to do otherwise.

One terrain dominates. If one terrain type dominates the map and there are no barriers, every day of travel feels the same. Players stop exploring because they already know what the next hex looks like.

Terrain as wallpaper. When terrain is purely visual, players stop reading the map for tactical information. They travel in straight lines, ignore terrain boundaries, and miss the strategic layer that makes hexcrawl navigation interesting.

Seasons without mechanics. When seasons have no mechanical effect, players ignore the calendar entirely. Time becomes an abstraction rather than a resource, and the campaign loses the rhythmic tension of deadlines, scarcity, and preparation.

Settlements

Settlements without logic. Settlements placed for aesthetic reasons without geographic logic create a region that looks good on the map but falls apart when players ask "why is this here?"

Rigid environmental culture. You derive culture so rigidly from environment that every mountain settlement feels identical. Environment provides a starting point, not a straitjacket. One mountain village might've discovered a hot spring, changing everything about its economy and values. Let oddities exist.

Identical outsider stances. Every settlement treats the party the same way. If strangers always receive the same welcome, the world feels like a single culture with one face. Vary the stance, and make sure at least one settlement on your map is actively suspicious to outsiders.

Factions

Same goals, different flags. All three factions want roughly the same thing. "Control the region" is not a goal, it is a default. When every faction pushes in the same direction, the world feels like a monolith with different flags. Distinct, incompatible goals are what produce the tension players navigate.

Traces too cryptic or obvious. Faction traces are so cryptic that players never connect them, or so obvious that they function as signposts. Calibrate by asking: could a careful player link this trace to a previous one after seeing three examples? If yes, the difficulty's right.

Tracking too many factions. You track eight factions, each with branching plans and contingencies. Session prep takes longer than the session itself. Keep to three to five active factions. The world only needs to feel alive, not be a full simulation.

Ruins

Ruins that explain themselves. Every ruin contains a journal that explains exactly what happened. Players stop investigating because ruins always hand them the answer.

Empty, pristine ruins. Every ruin is pristine and empty, waiting for the party to arrive. Ruins without current occupants or ecological activity feel like theme park attractions that activate when players walk through the door. Something should already be there.

History

No tension in the facts. Four facts that all agree with each other produce a setting without tension. “It’s cold, there are mountains, people are tough, and the winters are harsh” is four facts pointing in the same direction. Players nod along and wait for you to tell them what’s interesting. The twist is what makes them lean forward.

History only in your notes. Detailed history that exists only in your notes produces a GM who lectures and players who zone out. If the past isn’t on the map, it isn’t in the game.

Too many layers. You build so many layers that you lose track of what’s actually visible now. If your notes describe three civilizations but don’t specify what the ruin looks like standing in the rain, you’ve built a museum exhibit instead of an adventure location.

Every oddity is artificial. Every unusual landform turns out to be artificial. Players stop seeing natural terrain as natural. Vary your answers.

Unpronounceable names. You build an elaborate constructed language and name every feature in it. Players can’t pronounce, remember, or distinguish the names. If players default to “that place with the tower,” the name has failed.

Dead faction overshadows the living. The dead faction’s history is so detailed that it overshadows the living world. Current factions become footnotes to a more interesting past. Keep the dead faction to three bullet points and spend your remaining energy on the present.

History that produces nothing. You spend three sessions’ worth of prep time on history that produces zero moments during play. Track your ratio: every hour of history prep should generate at least two concrete details players can find. If it doesn’t, you’re writing a novel, not prepping a game.

Growth

Useless wildlife encounters. You build a detailed ecosystem but stock it with creatures your party can’t interact with in any interesting way. Wildlife serves the game when it produces encounters that create decisions. A perfectly accurate food chain that generates nothing but “you see deer grazing” has missed the point.

Building too far ahead. You build too far ahead. Two regions beyond the players is wasted prep. The campaign will change direction, factions will shift, and those distant hexes will need rewriting. Stay one region ahead. Never more.

Defining places instead of effects. You define places instead of effects. You write three pages about the Kestrani Empire’s succession laws and military structure. None of that reaches the players until an actual Kestrani merchant walks into the tavern offering silk at unusual prices. Start with the merchant and the silk. Build the empire when the players ask where the silk comes from.

Cleared locations stay empty. Cleared locations stay permanently empty. The bandit fort the party raided three sessions ago is still an abandoned ruin with nothing in it. The world feels like it pauses until the players arrive and resumes only where they are standing. Fill every vacuum.

APPENDIX B:

WORLDBUILDING CHECKLISTS

Print this page and keep it with your session notes. The build checklist takes thirty minutes to verify. The maintenance checklist takes ten minutes per session.

Build Checklist

Before the first session in a new region, confirm:

- ☐ Three facts and a twist are written down
- ☐ Terrain is sketched (hex types assigned, transitions make geographic sense)
- ☐ Three ages of history are defined, each with physical evidence on the map
- ☐ At least two settlements exist with location reason, product, need, and problem
- ☐ Three factions are active, with named leaders and incompatible goals
- ☐ Connections link settlements, factions, and terrain (trade routes, contested resources, cross-references)
- ☐ At least one unkeyed hex remains on the map for discovery during play

Maintenance Checklist (Between Sessions)

After each session, spend ten minutes:

- ☐ **Location update:** Mark any location that changed status (cleared, claimed, damaged, discovered).
- ☐ **Faction update:** Write one sentence per active faction describing what they did this week.
- ☐ **NPC shift:** Note any change in an NPC's attitude toward the players, with direction and cause.
- ☐ **Seasonal check:** Flag approaching seasonal changes that would affect terrain, travel, or resources.
- ☐ **Unkeyed area check:** If the players are heading toward an unkeyed area, key one or two hexes before next session.
- ☐ **Rumor refresh:** Drop a new rumor pointing toward unexplored content if the party needs direction.

Card Templates

Every card template from Chapters 2 through 7 is reproduced here for easy printing. Copy the template for each entity in your region and fill it in as play develops.

The Terrain Card

Terrain Type: _____

Build (before session 1)

Hex coverage : _____

Key barriers : _____

Checkpoint locations : _____

Deepen (when travel feels flat)

Movement cost : _____

Primary danger : _____

Available resource : _____

Visibility range : _____

Good season effect : _____

Bad season effect : _____

The Settlement Card

SETTLEMENT: _____

Build (before session 1)

Location reason : _____

Produces : _____

Needs : _____

Current problem : _____

Deepen (when it feels generic)

Food : _____

Greeting : _____

Value : _____

Taboo : _____

Architecture : _____

Outsider stance (one of)

Suspicion Hospitality

Exploitation Indifference

Maintain (between sessions)

NPC attitude shift : _____

Seasonal resource change : _____

The Faction Card

FACTION: _____

Build (before session 1)

Identity : _____

Goal : _____

Next action : _____

Territory : _____

Named NPC : _____

Deepen (when factions feel invisible)

Common trace : _____

Uncommon trace : _____

Rare trace : _____

Maintain (between sessions)

This week's action : _____

Status change : _____

The Ruin Card

Ruin: _____

Build (before session 1)

Era : _____

Visible fact : _____

Deepen (when ruins need depth)

Clue (evidence) : _____

Mystery (question) : _____

Possible resolution 1 : _____

Possible resolution 2 : _____

Current inhabitants : _____

Ecology state (one of)

Recent Occupied Reclaimed

The Region History Card

Region: _____

Build (before session 1)

Three facts : _____

Twist : _____

Age 1 (what/why ended) : _____

Age 2 (what/why ended) : _____

Age 3 (what/why ended) : _____

Deepen (when history feels thin)

Hidden layer : _____

Oddity : _____

Naming guide (3+3) : _____

The Growth Card

Region Growth: _____

Deepen (when the ecosystem needs logic)

Top predator : _____

What it hunts : _____

What prey eat : _____

Deepen (when players reach the edges)

Next region direction : _____

Carried faction : _____

Carried history : _____

Carried terrain : _____

Off-map influences:

1. : _____

2. : _____

3. : _____

Maintain (between sessions)

Cleared : _____

Protected : _____

Angered : _____

Built : _____

Glossary

Key terms introduced in this book.

Chokepoint. A pass, river crossing, bridge, or gate where terrain forces travel through a single hex. Natural locations for forts, tolls, and faction borders. (Chapter 2.)

Dead faction. A faction that no longer exists but whose built infrastructure, broken alliances, and left-behind artifacts drive current conflict. (Chapter 6.)

Faction trace. Visible evidence a faction leaves on the landscape: patrol routes, markers, caches, cleared roads, burned buildings. (Chapter 4.)

Implication web. The network of connections where each hex references at least one neighbor, turning the map into a puzzle players solve through exploration. (Chapter 1, Step 6.)

Layered map. A hex map where multiple historical layers are visible simultaneously: current roads following older roads, old foundations in current walls. (Chapter 6.)

Naming guide. A six-word guide per culture (three example words, three banned sounds) for improvising consistent place names during play. (Chapter 6.)

Outsider stance. A settlement's default response to strangers: hospitality, suspicion, exploitation, or indifference. (Chapter 3.)

Ruin ecology. The principle that abandoned places don't stay empty. Plants, animals, and new inhabitants reshape old structures. Tagged as recent, occupied, or reclaimed. (Chapter 5.)

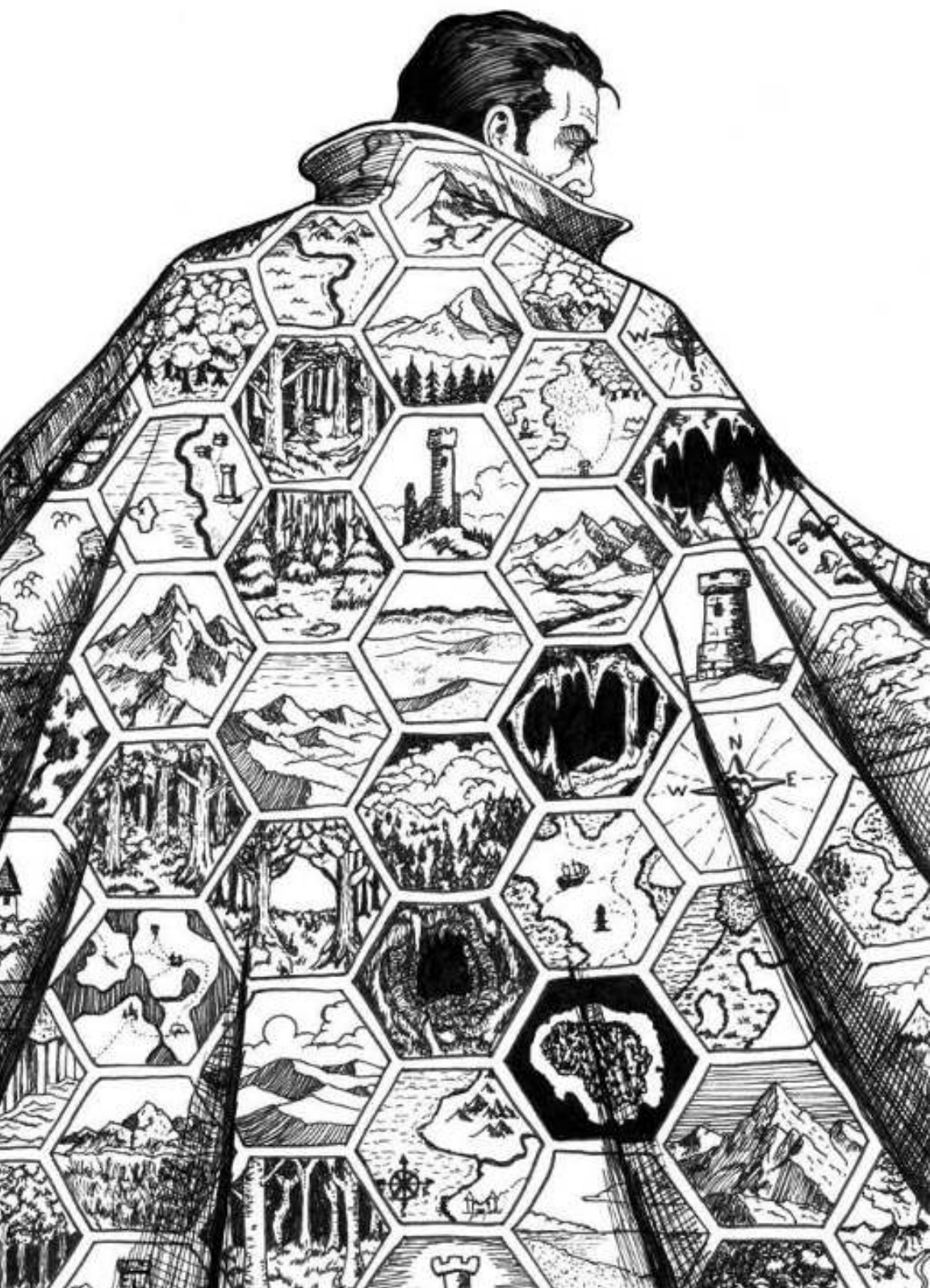
Settlement note. A settlement written as a short note: location reason, product, need, and current problem. (Chapter 1, Step 4.)

Show, don't tell. Setting details reach players through play (discovery, ruins, rumors, NPC conversations), not through backstory dumps. History is a spice in a meal, not a menu to read beforehand. (Introduction.)

Terrain transition. The hex where one terrain type meets another. Transitions combine features from two environments and are prime locations for encounters and settlements. (Chapter 2.)

The logic test. Pick any element and ask whether a local resident could explain why it exists. If the answer requires GM-only knowledge, rewrite it. (Chapter 1, Step 6.)

Three facts and a twist. Three facts establish baseline (land, people, history). The twist introduces what doesn't fit and demands investigation. The twist is the engine of play. (Chapter 1, Step 1.)





PRESENTS

THE HEXCRAWL SERIES

The World That Felt Alive: *The party explores a forest ruin and finds dry stone channels leading toward the valley. Later, a farmer complains that his fields flood because "the old drainage" stopped working generations ago. Same channels. Someone built an irrigation network across the region, then vanished. Every ruin becomes a clue.*

Deep lore? No. Smart connections.

This book gives you a six-step process to build a playable region in one evening. Layer history into terrain, ruins, roads, and factions so every location connects to another. A worked example takes you from blank page to session one, while a five-minute audit helps improve regions you already have.

System-neutral. *For GMs who want worlds that feel alive beyond the players' immediate view.*

THE SERIES

The Hexcrawl Guidebook *covers maps, exploration turns, and the procedures that hold a hexcrawl together. Start here if you're new.*

The Encounter Design Guidebook *is the next step when your random tables feel thin. It covers the four encounter categories, faction presence, slow threats, and pacing across a day of travel.*